

FREE SAMPLE

Budgie Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 52-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Colors, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 52 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 47 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/budgie/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free budgie care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/budgie/, and stays free.

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A budgie and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read the profile and housing pages, 4 to 11, before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the cage on page 6, which people buy small and replace, and whether you bring home one budgie or two on page 18. Settle both, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 38 to buy once instead of twice.

If your budgie is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, then read page 13 if the bird is on a seed mix: diet drives most of the health problems on the health pages, and the change takes days to months, so starting it today matters more than finishing this book first. If anything looks wrong, go straight to Red Flags on page 29.

Print these first

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| ☐ Page 36: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 44: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 37: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 45: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 41: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 46: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 42: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 47: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

A budgie is sold as the cheap, easy starter bird, and a lot of the advice in circulation was written to match that price rather than the animal: seed-only feeding, a cage the bird cannot fly across, and a kitchen as the cage spot. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary and published sources listed on page 50.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is a vet call, not a page in this book, and a budgie hides illness until it is far along. Find an avian vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Melopsittacus undulatus</i> . Sold in the United States as a parakeet, and elsewhere as a budgerigar or budgie. Same bird.
Adult size	About 7 in (18 cm); 25 to 35 g
Captive lifespan	7 to 15 years; the oldest documented bird lived 29 years, 2 months
Native range	The semi-arid interior of Australia, where huge nomadic flocks follow rainfall and seed
Diet type	A grass-seed eater in the wild; in captivity 60 to 80% pellets, with vegetables and a little fruit (page 12)
Cage, one bird	18×18×18 in (46×46×46 cm) as an absolute minimum; 30×18×18 in (76×46×46 cm) for a pair. Wider beats taller.
Bar spacing	Half an inch (1.3 cm) or less
Room temperature	65 to 85°F (18 to 29°C), with 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C) ideal. No drafts, direct sun or sudden swings.
Darkness and light	10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness every night. Without unfiltered sunlight, a full-spectrum UV (ultraviolet) light made for birds for 10 to 12 hours a day.
Sexing	By cere color in an adult of a standard color; some color varieties need a DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) test (page 25)
Handling difficulty	Beginner; a hand-raised bird may step up on day one
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$315 to \$750 for a complete starter setup, bird included (\$20 to \$80 of it), plus \$45 to \$65 for the first avian vet exam. A bare-minimum first year comes to about \$600. Every line is on page 38.

Monthly ongoing

\$25 to \$60 for food, toys, perches and cuttlebone, with the yearly well-bird exam spread across the months; \$20 to \$55 without it.

THE LINE ITEM PEOPLE LEAVE OUT

Avian vets are scarcer and pricier than dog or cat vets, and pet insurance is rarely available for a budgie. Tests add to the exam, an emergency exam alone is \$50 to \$75 before any treatment, and emergency treatment or surgery runs \$100 to \$1,500 or more. Set money aside for it.

Fun facts worth knowing

- A budgie named Puck holds the record for the largest vocabulary of any bird: an estimated 1,728 words before his death in 1994.
- A budgie's beak never stops growing, which is why it needs something safe to chew on.
- Budgies are prey animals and hide illness, so a bird that looks sick has usually been sick for a while.

The species, colors, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species, three names

The pet budgie is *Melopsittacus undulatus*. "Parakeet" is a broad, non-scientific word for many small to medium parrots with long tails, and a United States pet store that sells a bird labeled only "parakeet" is almost always selling a budgie. Ring-necked and monk parakeets are different species entirely. In the wild the budgie lives in open grassland, scrubland and open woodland in the interior of Australia, in nomadic flocks that can run to thousands, eating grass seeds, berries and other plant matter. It feeds on or near the ground, taking whichever seeds are in season. It is small, swift and highly social, and it is the best-selling pet bird in the world.

Colors and types

Standard blue and standard gray budgies follow the cere-color rule on page 25. Pastel and solid-color mutations do not, because their cere stays pinkish lavender for life. Alongside the ordinary pet bird there is a heavier show type, bred for exhibition. The care in this package applies to all of them.

Size and age

Length	About 7 in (18 cm)
Weight	25 to 35 g for a healthy adult. Your own bird's settled weight matters more than the range (page 16).
Telling age	Two features date a budgie at a glance: the barring on the forehead recedes as the bird ages, and the iris, dark in a youngster, turns gray. Full forehead bars and solid dark eyes mean a young bird.
Adult cere color	Settles between 6 and 12 months old

Lifespan

7 to 15 years is typical in captivity. Diet drives most of the health problems that shorten a budgie's life, which is why so much of this package is about food. A budgie bought for a 10-year-old can still be on its perch when that child leaves for college, so plan for the whole span: the routine, the cage and an avian vet for every one of those years.

Talking and noise

Budgies are among the best talkers for their size, and single males tend to be the best of all. Their constant chatter sits at a gentle, background volume that most households barely notice, much softer than a cockatiel. Most pet birds are loudest at dawn and dusk, a habit that comes from wild contact calling.

FLOCK FIRST

Everything about a budgie follows from being a flock bird. It wants company all day, it feels safest with a wall at its back, and movement above or behind it reads as a predator. The housing and handling pages are built on those three facts.